transfer the resulting currency on behalf of certain countries to Poland, in order to allow it to alleviate in part its critical financial situation and purchase some vitally needed foodstuffs and other products.

As for the GDR, if you agree, then the amount of oil supplies from the Soviet Union could be cut back in 1981 by 600–650,000 tons from the agreed level, all this without touching the level of supplies of German products to the Soviet Union. I am asking you, Erich, to treat this suggestion with empathy. I am certain that this manifestation of fraternal solidarity will allow our Polish comrades to weather this difficult hour. With communist greetings,

L. Brezhnev11

Although shaken by the economic implications of Brezhnev's note, Honecker's nervousness at the political situation was revealed in his reply in which he requested an urgent meeting of the General and First Secretaries of the Communist Parties:

According to information we have received through various channels, counter-revolutionary forces in the People's Republic of Poland are on the constant offensive, and any delay in acting against them would mean death – the death of socialist Poland. Yesterday our collective efforts may perhaps have been premature; today they are essential; and tomorrow they would already be too late.12

When it happened, the emergency meeting of the Warsaw Pact held in Moscow on 5 December, saw Honecker call for extreme measures. Alluding to 1953, he ruefully reminded his audience that: